

Pacific Ocean

THE LARGEST OCEAN ON EARTH, the Pacific covers one-third of Earth's surface. The island nations of Japan, Indonesia, Australia, New Zealand, and many others are completely surrounded by this enormous ocean, which stretches from the Arctic in the north to the Southern Ocean in the south. The Pacific is also the world's deepest ocean – its greatest known depth is in the Mariana Trench, off Guam, which plunges steeply for 36,198 ft (11,033 m). Within the Pacific, there are many smaller seas that lie near land. These include the Tasman Sea, the South China Sea, and the Bering Sea. There are more than 30,000 islands in the Pacific. Most are too small or barren to be inhabited, but others are home to people of many different cultures and religions. The native island peoples fall into three main groups—Polynesians, Melanesians, and Micronesians. Although the word *pacific* means “peaceful,” strong currents, tropical storms, and tsunamis can all make this ocean far from peaceful.

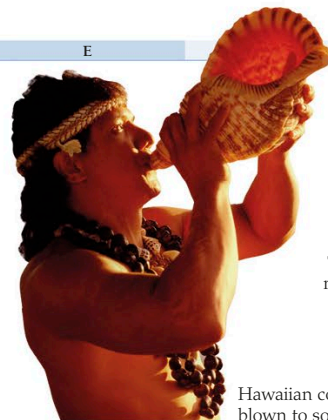
TSUNAMI

Earthquakes beneath the sea may cause giant waves called tsunamis. These can travel great distances across the ocean, building into a huge wall of water as they approach the coast. They can leave immense damage in their wake.



SURFING

The Hawaiian sport of surfing ranks as the oldest sport in the USA. It was first practiced by the nobility as a form of religious ceremony until the 1820s when missionaries, who thought it immoral, tried to ban it. Today, surfing is one of the most popular watersports and can be seen all over the world, from Australia to the UK.



Hawaiian conch shells, once blown to sound a warning

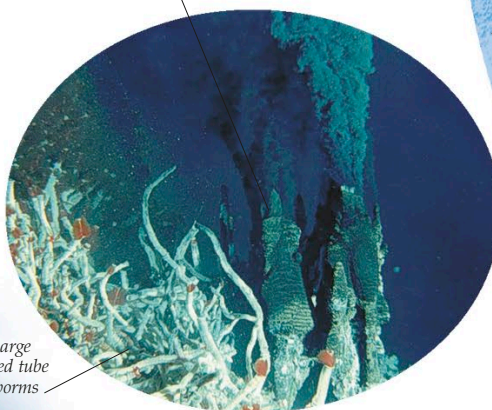


Marine iguana on black volcanic rocks, Galápagos Islands

GALÁPAGOS ISLANDS

When British naturalist Charles Darwin (1809–1882) went to the Galápagos Islands, he found many unusual animals. He also noticed differences between animals of the same species living elsewhere. This led him to believe that, over time, animals adapt, or evolve, to suit their habitats.

Black smoker chimney



Large red tube worms

DEEP-SEA VENTS

Underwater exploration has revealed some amazing places deep in the Pacific. Large vents, formed by solidified minerals, act as chimneys for super-hot steam and gas that stream up from the sea bed. These vents are known as black smokers. Scientists have found a host of new creatures living in this hostile environment.

HAWAII

This chain of eight volcanic islands and 124 islets forms the 50th state of the United States, and was admitted to the union in 1959. The dramatic landscape and palm-fringed beaches make Hawaii a popular destination for tourists. Today, native Hawaiians are a minority in their own land.



The Pacific is larger than Earth's entire land surface.